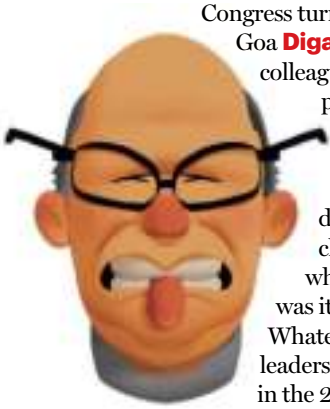
COSTLY DISCORD



Internal discord is becoming a worry for the ruling BJP in Gujarat. Ex-Speaker **Ramanlal Vora** is the latest to feel the heat, called out by a party colleague for 'posing' as a farmer and buying subsidised land in his family's name. The sidelined Vora had been lashing out at his party's government over sundry issues, so this could have been a way to keep him in line. That said, many feel targeting the BJP's tallest Dalit leader in the state may be a shortsighted strategy.

MISPLACED PROPHESY



Congress turncoat and new minister in Goa **Digambar Kamat** stunned BJP colleagues when he stated that the party would not come to power again in the state "for the next 50 years". Kamat was speaking at the birthday celebration of state BJP chief Damodar 'Damu' Naik when the slip of the tongue (or was it a Freudian slip?) happened. Whatever the reason, Congress leaders are already claiming victory in the 2027 assembly election.

LOW BLOW



With assembly polls round the corner, politics must be weighing heavy on his shoulders. Which is why it was no surprise to see RJD leader **Tejashwi Yadav** break into a jig in the company of several youngsters. A video posted by sister Rohini Acharya of his "fun time" quickly went viral traction. But where admirers saw spontaneity, rivals spied an opening. Like this quip from Jan Suraaj Party's Prashant Kishor: "I knew Tejashwi wasn't good at studies or cricket, now it's clear he can't dance either."

Kaushik Deka with Avishek G. Dastidar, Kavitha Muralidharan, Jumana Shah, Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Amitabh Srivastava

TECH WATCH

SMART WINDOWS
HUNT FOR A CHEAPER OPTION

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

Photochromic lenses, which darken when exposed to light, have been around for decades, but what about electrochromic smart windows, which do the same to keep out the blazing sun and also help reduce a building's energy bills? The idea is catching on globally, but the high cost of materials such as tungsten oxide and the lithium-based electrolytes used to make smart windows has hindered their wider adoption. A materials research group in Bengaluru may now have hit upon an affordable technology.

In a paper published in the nanotech journal *Small* in May, researchers from the Centre for Nano and Soft Matter Sciences (CeNS) experimented with aluminum ion-based electrolytes and titanium oxide, a low-cost compound used commonly as a UV filter in sunscreens. The key problem they tried to solve was the limited coloration efficiency of titanium oxide. For this, they altered the material's properties via a technique of engineering 'oxygen vacancies' (messing with the oxygen atoms in its structure).

The lab-scale demonstration showed a potential reduction of 7-8° Celsius in indoor temperature



using this material, says Dr Ashutosh K. Singh, who led the Department of Science and Technology-funded research project. "If you can reduce the cost so that everyone can instal these, we are ultimately talking about carbon neutrality," he says. But there's still a long way to go. Singh places their smart window tech at Level 3/4 on a 9-point scale. That means a lot more industrial testing before you can bring a product home.